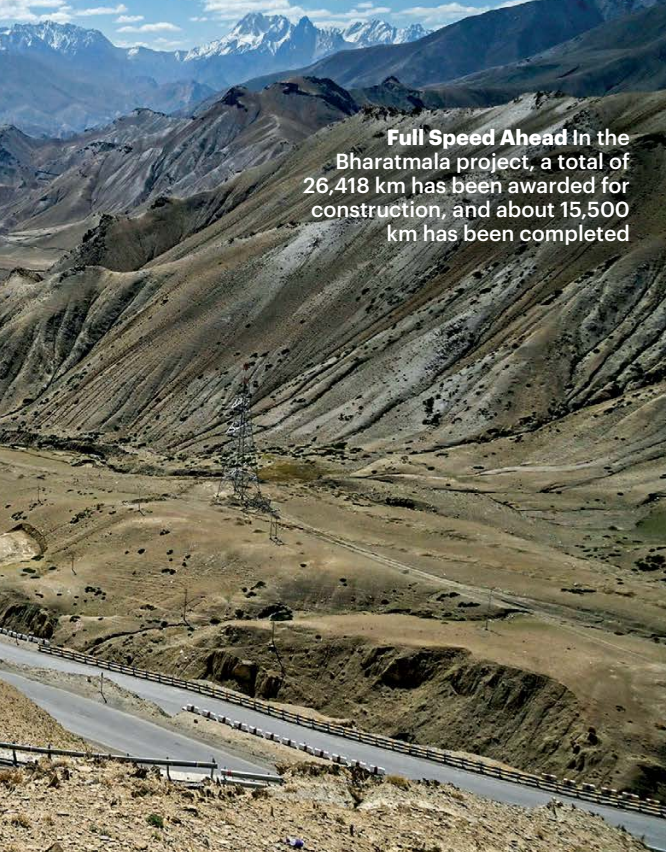
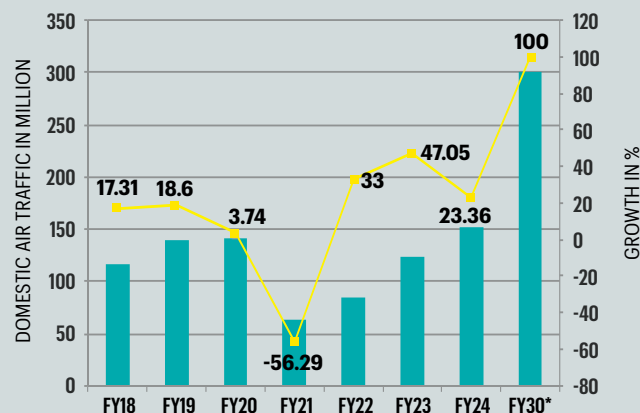




Full Speed Ahead In the Bharatmala project, a total of 26,418 km has been awarded for construction, and about 15,500 km has been completed

THE AERIAL ROUTE

● Domestic air passenger traffic is expected to double by 2030 ● Indian carriers have placed huge orders of aircraft to cater to this



● DOMESTIC AIR PASSENGER TRAFFIC (LHS) — ANNUAL GROWTH (RHS); * PROJECTED SOURCE DGCA

33.8 km in FY24 and taking it to 40 km per day.

But by far the biggest challenge for the BJP veteran is increasing private investment in the sector. As of now, most highway projects are awarded under engineering, procurement, and construction (EPC) with 100% funding from the government. Under EPC, a contractor is made responsible for the project from the initial survey to completion. Considerable efforts have been made to streamline policy-related issues to attract private players.

Reducing the National Highways Authority of India's (NHAI) debt of ₹3.4 lakh crore is another critical area for Gadkari.

AVIATION

Meanwhile, Naidu of the TDP needs to pilot the Indian aviation sector

amidst operational turbulence. The government has envisaged a capex of ₹4 lakh crore just for modernisation, technology upgrades, and providing world-class facilities.

According to aviation consultancy firm CAPA, Indian airlines are expected to post an industry-wide loss of between \$400 million and \$600 million in FY25 despite 6-8% domestic traffic growth.

Naidu takes charge amid demands that carriers like Qatar, Emirates, and Etihad Airways relax bilateral rights. At present, they operate 65,000 seats weekly to India, and Indian airlines operate 65,000 seats to Dubai every week. This agreement was last revised in 2015. The domestic aviation industry is split over relaxing these rights—while Air India

has opposed increasing foreign airlines' seats, IndiGo has called for wider consultation, but Akasa supports the move.

Another proposal is developing India as an international transit hub, since more than 50% of Indian passengers continue to use airports in Dubai and Singapore as transit hubs.

The airport modernisation plan is already in the pipeline, apart from putting smaller cities on India's aviation map through the UDAN (Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik) scheme. The government plans to add another 100 airports to the 148 that exist today.

Despite the rapid growth in the Indian aviation sector, big aircraft equipment manufacturers have shied away from setting up units in

India. This has forced Indian firms to depend on foreign players for spare parts and ancillaries.

A pressing concern is the shortage of pilots and the working conditions of commercial pilots. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation, the regulator for the sector, issued a directive regulating pilots' duty hours and reducing night-time flying. This was withdrawn later. With Indian airlines looking to induct 1,600 new aircraft over the next 10 years, the availability of trained pilots requires immediate attention.

It's clear that there's a lot that's left to be done in setting up the Modi government's 'Vision 2047'. It's time now to act, and fast. **BT**

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